COORDINATED CLAMPDOWN

- In March, CM Ashok Gehlot introduced the Rajasthan Control of Organised Crime Bill in the state assembly, which among other stricter provisions will make it tough for gangsters to get bail
- Police have launched the 'Area Domination, Raid and Search Campaign'. In one such statewide operation carried out on April 25, 4,143 teams raided 12,854 sites and arrested 8,950 criminals
- On April 16, the reward money on fugitives was enhanced after a decade. The DGP now has the power to announce a reward of Rs 5 lakh, up from Rs 1 lakh
- On CM's orders, police have identified 2,471 ill-gotten properties of criminals; info is being passed on to the I-T and other authorities; a few unauthorised ones razed
- Police are also keeping an eye on the social media accounts of criminals. Cases lodged for displaying arms against followers; parents of minor followers told to counsel their children

also disrupt efforts to attract youngsters through social media.

"We often carry out early-morning raids in several districts in one go with heavy deployment," adds Dinesh. "This stuns the criminals, creating fear among them. It also gives people confidence and they start coming forward with information against the law-breakers." Rajasthan cops, however, used to eschew encounters as a practice. "We did not want our cops to turn trigger-happy," says a senior bureaucrat. In fact, there have been only four encounter deaths since 2019. This year, though, the guns are out. In the first three months of 2023, 21 criminals have been injured in encounters and 25 shot at while trying to escape. They include three suspects from the G-Club firing who were shot in the leg when they allegedly tried to flee while being brought from Agra on January 30.

EYES ON THE GANGSTERS

The police have also been keeping an eye on the social media accounts of these criminals as they have become a significant lure for the youth, who follow them for their lifestyle and the display of arms. For instance, Deva Gurjar, who was brutally killed in a gang war in April 2022, would often upload reels and glimpses of his lifestyle that cast him in the image of a Hindi film villain. He had more than 200,000 followers on Instagram. "Some criminals had become so bold that they publicised their murders on social media," says Dinesh. In Bhiwadi, two criminals claimed responsibility for a murder on social media as did the two men who had killed a tailor in a hate crime in Udaipur last year.



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DINESH M.N.
Additional Director General, Crime, Rajasthan Police

As a deterrent, Rajasthan's cops have now lodged over 350 cases against the followers, including under the Arms Act for displaying weapons on social media, and arrested 56 of them. About a 1,000 were also put in preventive detention for a day or two. Parents of a few, especially minors, were called to police stations to ask them to counsel their children. This has seen results. The number of Facebook followers of Rohit Godara, Bishnoi's aide who had claimed responsibility for Theth's murder, has nearly halved.

Currently, the police have half a dozen gangs in their sights. Besides the Bishnoi gang, other prominent criminal groups include the Lala gang in Chittorgarh who are into narcotics and the Manju gang of Jodhpur, also into narcotics as well as extortion. Then there's the Jabbar gang in Pali that faces 90 cases of real estate encroachment, extortion and conspiracy to murder among other charges, says Dinesh. On Gehlot's orders, police have identified 2,471 ill-gotten properties of such criminals and are passing on the information to the income tax and other authorities. The unauthorised properties of a few have also been razed. "We have a long way to go," admits Mishra, adding that there will be proactive policing and no let-up in raids.

But Diya Kumari, the BJP MP from Rajsamand, describes the recent crackdown as "too little, too late". "It is shocking the way criminals have got a strong footing in Rajasthan—a state known for peace and hospitality," says the MP, alleging that police were lax earlier in dealing with criminals because of the "connivance or patronage of Congress leaders". "After what happened in Churu and Udaipur, we can see that one or two mass raids have failed to act as a deterrent," she adds. On April 26, a day after the statewide raids, three men fired 15 rounds outside a jewellery shop in Churu, injuring a cop deployed for security of its owner who had received an extortion call. The very next day, seven cops on an operation to nab a notorious criminal were injured after being attacked by a mob in Udaipur. In the crosshairs themselves, the Rajasthan Police seem to be in it for the long haul. ■